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Companies that focus on continued reinvention to meet the changing preferences of customers will stay ahead of the curve

FIVE MANTRAS FOR TODAY'S CEO

With India's progress, challenges have grown for the modern Indian CEO. These five action steps, therefore, are most crucial

GENERATIVE ARTIFICIAL intelligence (Gen AI) is rapidly transforming the business landscape. With every passing day, its influence in shaping business operations is proving to be more real than hype. Companies that do not recognise or leverage its transformative potential may find it hard to remain economically viable over the next decade or so. PwC's *27th Annual Global CEO Survey: India* perspective, accordingly, highlights the imperative for companies to reinvent—especially with Gen AI—not only to stay the course but also to increase revenue and profitability.

While CEOs in general have been upbeat about the Indian economy, numerous social challenges barricade India's road to economic prosperity. A well-defined strategy comprising the following five action steps can perhaps help businesses gain a competitive advantage while remaining viable in the long run.

BUILDING TRUST

Technological preparedness and the availability of skilled talent have positioned India as an attractive investment and manufacturing destination. India has risen to the fifth position as an investment destination for global CEOs, up from the ninth position it held in 2023, PwC's *27th Annual Global CEO Survey* has revealed. Moreover, the country has also improved its Ease of Doing Business (EoDB) ranking. Nonetheless,

businesses continue to be pinched by the burden of compliance, governed as they are by over 1,500 Acts and nearly 70,000 compliances. But what if a company were to shift its perspective and view regulatory compliance as an opportunity and not a barrier? Regulatory compliance can help businesses build trust with their stakeholders and position themselves as ethical and responsible leaders. For instance, if businesses were to show that their business operations comply with the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, that can reassure customers that their data is being handled responsibly.

CUSTOMER PREFERENCES

For Indian business leaders, changing customer preferences is the top reinvention driver. The survey shows that 61% of respondents said that customer preferences had led to changes in how their companies created, delivered and captured value in the last five years. It follows, therefore, that companies that focus on continued reinvention to meet the changing preferences of customers will stay ahead of the curve. Recent PwC research suggests that companies can fulfil customer needs by working across industry boundaries. Retail companies can leverage Gen AI, for instance, to enhance customer engagement and personalise product recommendations. Also, with more customers using their smartphones to research products